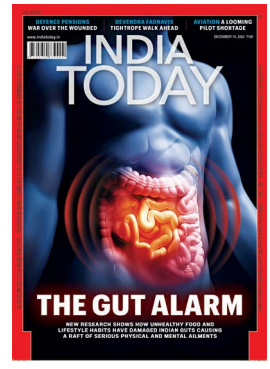
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Considering the significance of the liver in a person's health, it is often treated as the step-child to all the other organs of the body. The heart, the flamboyant workhorse of the body, gets its full share of attention, but the liver is not talked about enough. That's odd, for it is the only regenerative organ in the body. It is also the source of many ailments. A malfunctioning liver is detrimental to metabolic health, putting the person at risk of a cascading set of mutually reinforcing ailments, including diabetes, poor gut health, obstructive sleep apnea and gastroesophageal reflux disease, many of which can be fatal.

The liver is the body's largest organ and immune gland. A normal liver weighs only 1.5 kg in an adult, but at any given point, it holds at least 13 per cent of the body's blood supply. All the blood leaving the digestive tract passes through this organic sorting house; it's here that the nutrients get broken down, repackaged and dispatched to different parts of the body, with toxic byproducts packed off to waste disposal. And that's only one of its roles. What this complex organ performs is akin to a whole one-piece symphony orchestra, with a part in over 500 vital functions: metabolic, immunological and purificatory. For all that, this powerhouse works silently in the back office, efficiently multi-tasking and not even letting us know. But it turns out that liver disorders in India are reaching epidemic proportions.



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Earlier, barring hepatitis cases, liver ailments were linked purely to those who had an excessive fondness for alcohol. Cirrhosis, the chronic liver disease that destroys its healthy tissues and replaces them with scars that prevent normal functioning, was seen as a consequence of alcoholism. But no more. A new scourge is upon us: non-alcoholic fatty liver disease (NAFLD). It is caused by multiple factors that include obesity and poor dietary habits. Without most of us being aware of this hidden danger, its prevalence in India has crept up uncomfortably close to 40 per cent of the population. Alarmingly, even among Indian children, studies reveal over 35 per cent prevalence.

So serious is the issue that, in 2021, India became the first country to declare NAFLD a non-communicable disease, putting us at the forefront of the global fight against it. That year, India topped the global charts for all-cause liver mortality rates: 277,130 deaths, nearly double that of runner-up China. All the enemies of the liver tend to hunt in packs, and NAFLD is now a leading part of the army that lays a siege on this crucial organ.

The tricky part is that its symptoms don't manifest very quickly; NAFLD is a stealth weapon, striking even people who seem otherwise healthy. A person is designated as suffering from it if the liver has accumulated over 5 per cent of fat. However, even when diagnosed, patients tend to take it lightly because the liver can grow back to its original size even if over 90 per cent has been removed or damaged. But a fatty liver is sluggish and, ultimately, a curse on itself.

The key thing to remember is expressed best by Dr S.K. Sarin, chairman of the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences in Delhi and one of India's top hepatologists: "Though it's much more common in overweight and obese people, you don't need to be fat or eat fat to have a fatty liver." In fact, a 2021 study published in *Clinical Liver Disease* found 10-15 per cent of Indian NAFLD patients to be lean, with a standard body mass index. Eventually, some of them may experience fatigue, a feeling of fullness, nausea, jaundice, dark urine, or mild liver enlargement. But by the time they are diagnosed, they have lived with fat in the liver long enough for it to have suffered its corrosive effects. Experts say ignoring NAFLD, even for a short duration, can have serious consequences.

For our cover story this week, Senior Editor Sonali Acharjee spoke to eminent doctors and confused patients for a 360-degree scan. She found that much of NAFLD is caused by what we eat. When we consume excess calories, the surplus gets converted into body fat. The liver is the primary site for de novo lipogenesis, or the production of new fat from excess carbohydrates. Some of it settles right there, as part of dangerous visceral fat. So, with the carbohydrate-reliant diet of Indians, we are the most vulnerable. Screening and early detection are crucial because untreated NAFLD can lead to more complicated disorders, proceeding from steatohepatitis (liver inflammation caused by fat) to cirrhosis and even liver cancer. Luckily, diagnostic procedures are becoming more sophisticated, with newer tests like transient elastography. There is no specific medication; the usual recommendation is permanent lifestyle changes—diet, exercise and weight loss. Losing even 10 per cent of your body weight is seen to have a powerful effect in reducing liver fat. 'Central obesity' was found to be the common risk factor in 84 per cent of Indian patients, so shedding abdominal fat is key. We give you the entire lowdown, from liver-friendly food to treatment options.

But most of all, this is a wake-up call. There was a time when we could live without thinking much about the liver. These are deadlier times. To live well, treat your liver well.

(Aroon Purie)